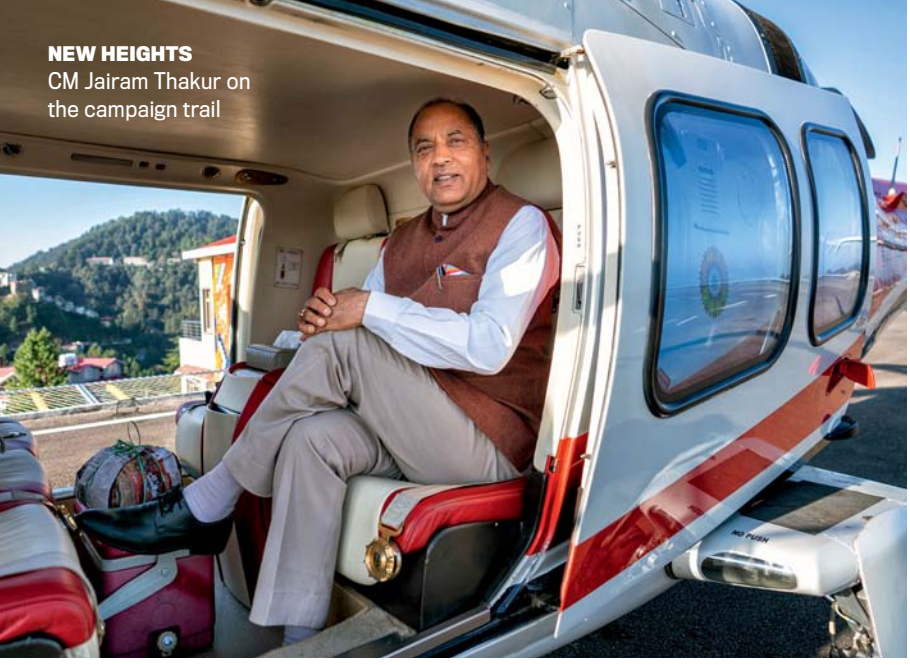


NEW HEIGHTS
CM Jairam Thakur on the campaign trail

SANDEEP SAHDEV

in the hills and that the faction backing Union minister Anurag Thakur and his father, the former CM Prem Kumar Dhumal, had been cut to size. The BJP has 23 new faces this time and faces rebellion in 14 seats. Five leaders have already been expelled, among them four ex-MLAs and ex-MP Kirpal Parmar. Kullu candidate Maheshwar Singh, too, has lost his ticket after failing to dissuade his son Hiteshwar Singh from contesting in neighbouring Banjar. Party insiders feel the rebels may play spoiler in 5-6 seats.

The trouble runs deeper for the Congress. Many of the rebels are from the erstwhile Virbhadra camp. The BJP has already poached Pratibha's chief strategist and ex-Himachal Congress chief, Harsh Mahajan. Another family loyalist, Pawan Kajal, is now the BJP candidate in Kangra. Some leaders, who were denied tickets, are also rebelling. Then, there are the factions led by senior leaders like Kuldeep Singh Rathod, Sukhwinder Singh Sukhu, Asha Kumari, Mukesh Agnihotri and former Union minister Anand Sharma. As a compromise, Sukhu was made chairman of the campaign committee and Agnihotri retained as leader of the opposition, but matters are far from sorted.

Rebels could disrupt the prospects of both parties. In 2017, the margin of victory in 20 seats was less than 3,000 votes, and under 1,000 in six seats. The BJP garnered 48.8 per cent of the votes, the Congress 41.7 per cent (a dip of just 1.1 percentage point compared to 2012), and 9.5 per cent accrued to the smaller parties in the state. The BJP is already rueing the fact that the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) did not take off in Himachal, which may have split the Congress vote. Partymen must now work extra hard to save the day.

FREEBIE VS WELFARE

Taking a cue from the AAP playbook, the Congress in Himachal has come up with 10 guarantees, including free electricity up to 300 units, Rs 1,500 for every adult woman (above 18) in the state etc. Along with this, Pratibha has committed that if the Congress wins, the old pension scheme (OPS) will be reintroduced at the first cabinet meeting. Given that Himachal has 300,000 state employees, this could impact the result in Kangra, Hamirpur and Shimla districts. Never mind that OPS alone will require provisioning of Rs 600 crore for the state annually. A BJP leader in New Delhi says the CMs of other poll-bound states that the party rules, like Karnataka and Gujarat, are also putting pressure on the central leadership to look for ways to deal with the situation.

Vikramaditya insists these are not freebies, but relief measures for the people. "We have consulted economists and finance experts and there is room to deliver this," he says. "Congress is a responsible political party and we will deliver the commitments without jeopardising the state's finances."

Meanwhile, Thakur argues that his government is already giving 125 units of power free, with the benefits reaching 1.1 million of the 1.4 million consumers. The BJP regime has also made supply of drinking water free in rural areas, and gives a 50 per cent discount to women travellers in public transport. The party is also pushing the narrative among women voters of how the social sector schemes of the Centre and state benefit them the most. These include HimCare, a universal health insurance scheme (complementing Ayushman Bharat) and Grihini Suvidha Schemes, adding more beneficiaries to the PM Ujjwala Yojna. Thakur's government has spent Rs 120 crore to give additional cylinders to 335,000 beneficiaries of the latter.

The Congress believes that the sympathy for the Virbhadra family, along with organisational presence in the remotest parts of the state, should work in their favour. There are rumblings among state leaders, but they haven't reached the scale of, say, pre-poll Punjab.

Meanwhile, the BJP is falling back on PM Modi and the appeal for a nationalist, pro-Hindu vote. Himachal is, as one analyst put it, a 'hyper Hindu' state and even Congress leaders refrain from blatantly criticising Modi or some of his 'nationalist' moves like the abrogation of Article 370. The PM has already addressed four rallies and scheduled four more in the first 10 days of November. The PM's charisma apart, the BJP will also rely on its usual micro-management of the polls. On October 30, with leaders from central and state teams, the party held parallel rallies in 62 of the 68 seats to showcase its organisational skills.

The BJP's by-now standard SOP of effective booth management has paid dividends in recent polls in Uttar Pradesh, Goa, Uttarakhand and Manipur, where the party was able to curtail anti-incumbency to a large extent. This continues in Himachal with some 2,069 *gram kendra pramukhs* and over 35,000 *panna samitis* to monitor the 7,881 poll booths. Come December 8, and the state will know whether the military-style precision has worked or not. ■